

Chapter 03: A Short History of the Grant Study

Brief Summary

This long chapter tells the story of the Study as an institution. It explains who founded it, why it began, how the men were selected and studied, how the research questions changed over seventy-five years, and how scientific fashion shaped what investigators noticed or ignored. It is partly a history of American social science: early physiological optimism and body-type theories gave way to psychology, psychiatry, alcoholism research, adult development, attachment, and eventually neuroscience.

Key Study Findings

- Arlie Bock founded the Study to investigate positive health. He believed medicine paid too much attention to disease and too little to the conditions that allow people to live well.
- The early Study was shaped by 1930s assumptions: body build, physiology, constitutional medicine, and racial typology were treated as possible predictors of leadership and success.
- The original investigators collected enormous physical and psychological data, but they paid surprisingly little attention to friendship, romantic attachment, and intimate relationships.
- Lewise Gregory's family interviews were one of the Study's great assets. Her warmth and skill helped produce extraordinarily rich childhood data and maintained participant loyalty.
- The sample was privileged but not uniformly wealthy. Many men received scholarships, worked during college, or came from families without college-educated parents.
- The Study's low attrition was not just a technical success. It depended on decades of trust, tact, letters, interviews, and personal relationships between staff and participants.
- Scientific priorities shifted with directors: Bock and Heath emphasized health and physiology; McArthur emphasized social psychology; Vaillant emphasized adaptation, maturation, relationships, and alcoholism; Waldinger added late-life relationships, DNA, video, and brain imaging.
- Funding shaped findings. NIAAA support pushed alcoholism into view, and that became one of the Study's most important contributions.

Interesting Stories And Examples

- Art Miller's story is the chapter's emotional lesson. He disappeared from the Study for decades after becoming a drama teacher in Western Australia. Vaillant initially judged him as evasive and underachieving.
- When Vaillant later found wartime records documenting Miller's combat trauma, the life looked different. What had seemed like avoidance could be interpreted as posttraumatic growth and creative adaptation.
- The chapter also highlights the unseen labor of longitudinal research: Clark Heath's caring medical presence, Lewise Gregory's interviewing genius, and Robin Western's later detective work in keeping the men connected.

Why It Matters

The chapter shows that research is historical and relational. The Grant Study's findings were made possible not just by design, but by trust, persistence, money, changing theory, and the willingness to reinterpret old data.